

Pre Marital Sex And Cohabitation

prc-pre-marital-sex-and-cohabitation

Marriage & Sexuality · Sexual Ethics · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.950
confidence high

Statement under examination

Sexual intimacy is reserved for marriage between one man and one woman; pre-marital sex (fornication) and unmarried cohabitation that includes sexual relations are sin.

In plain language

Two lexical pillars carry this question. The first is the Greek word porneia, which appears 26 times in the New Testament as the broad term for illicit sexual intercourse. In 1 Corinthians 6:18 the command is to flee porneia, and the one who commits it is said to sin against his own body, using the verb hamartanei. In 1 Thessalonians 4:3 God's will, called sanctification, is to abstain from porneia. In Ephesians 5:3 porneia and all impurity must not even be named among the saints. Hebrews 13:4 lists pornous (the sexually immoral) separately from moichous (adulterers), so porneia is not narrowed to married people straying. Its Old Testament cognate, the Hebrew zanah, appears 91 times, and Deuteronomy 22:20-21 uses it for sexual relations by an unmarried woman before marriage, treating the absence of virginity-tokens as a punishable wrong. The second pillar is positive. Genesis 2:24 says a man leaves father and mother, cleaves (davaq) to his wife, and the two become one flesh (basar echad). That clause is cited three times in the New Testament, by Jesus at Matthew 19:5, by Paul at 1 Corinthians 6:16 (where joining to a prostitute is wrong because it misplaces the one-flesh bond), and by Paul at Ephesians 5:31. Hebrews 13:4 puts the same point as a standing: marriage, gamos, is honorable and the bed, he koite, is undefiled, amiantos, bounded by marriage itself. 1 Corinthians 7:2 names a man's own wife and a woman's own husband as the remedy for porneia. Where readers diverge, it tends to be over the exact width of porneia or whether the Old Testament case law in Exodus 22:16 and Deuteronomy 22:28 treats unmarried sex as a wrong remedied by marriage or as constituting marriage. Even on the narrower readings, the words still locate sexual union inside the husband-wife pair and treat sexual activity outside it as a sexual offense.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	
H1320	בשר	basar	flesh	250
H1331	בתולים	betulim	virginity	10
H1692	דבק	davaq	to cleave	46
H2181	זנה	zanah	to fornicate	91
H5003	נאף	naaph	to commit adultery	
G0038	ἁγιασμός	hagiasmos	holiness	10
G0167	ἀκαθαρσία	akatharsia	impurity	10
G0265	ἁμάρτημα	hamartema	sin	5
G0283	ἀμίαντος	amiantos	pure	4

G1060	γαμέω	gameo	to marry	28
G1062	γάμος	gamos	wedding	16
G1392	δοξάζω	doxazō	to glorify	
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithymia	desire	38
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	
G2398	ἴδιος	idios	one's own/private	
G2845	κοίτη	koite	bed	4
G2853	κολλάσμαι	kollaomai	to join	12
G3431	μοιχεύω	moicheuō	to commit adultery	
G3432	μοιχός	moichos	adulterer	4
G4202	πορνεία	porneia	sexual sin	26
G4203	πορνεύω	porneuo	to sin sexually	8
G4204	πόρνη	porne	prostitute	12
G4205	πόρνος	pornos	sexual sinner	10
G4347	προσκολλάω	proskollaō	to join	
G4561	σάρξ	sarx	flesh	
G4632	σκεῦος	skeuos	vessel	
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5092	τιμή	timē	honor	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical engine has two reinforcing parts. Positive: Gen 2:24 builds the cleaving and one-flesh formula from davaq (H1692) plus basar (H1320) plus echad (H0259), and that exact formula is quoted at Matt 19:5, 1 Cor 6:16, and Eph 5:31, locating one-flesh union inside the man-and-wife pair. Heb 13:4 sets the standing as timios ho gamos en pasin kai he koite amiantos (G1062, G2845, G0283), the marriage bed alone honored and undefiled. Negative: porneia (G4202, 26 NT occurrences) is the broad lexical category for illicit sexual intercourse and is the explicit object of prohibition (1 Cor 6:18 pheugete ten porneian, 1 Thess 4:3 apechesthai apo tes porneias, Eph 5:3 mede onomazestho), with porneuo verb form (G4203), pornos noun (G4205), porne noun (G4204). Heb 13:4 names pornous separately from moichous (G3432), so porneia is not narrowed to adultery. The OT cognate zannah (H2181, 91 occurrences) plus the betulim virginity case in Deut 22:14, 20-21 plus the seduction case in Exod 22:16 give an unbroken OT-to-NT pattern that brackets sexual relations inside marriage and labels intercourse outside it as wrong.

Scripture

Gen.2.24 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1692 דָּבַק; H1320 בָּשָׂר; H0259 אֶחָד.

Force. The foundational clause says a man leaves father and mother, cleaves (davaq, H1692) to his wife, and the two become one flesh (basar echad, H1320 plus H0259). The verb davaq paired with basar echad makes the one-flesh union an attribute of the husband-wife pair specifically, not of any sexual partnership. Matt 19:5, 1 Cor 6:16, and Eph 5:31 cite this verse with kollaomai and proskollao plus sarx, transferring the same boundary into the NT.

Deut.22.20 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H1331 בְּתוּלִים; H2181 זָנָה.

Force. Deut 22:20-21 makes the absence of betulim (virginity-tokens, H1331) at marriage prosecutable, and characterizes the act as zarah (H2181, to act as a prostitute or commit sexual immorality) committed in the father's house before marriage. The case law therefore explicitly classes premarital sex by an unmarried woman as zarah, the OT cognate of porneia.

Heb.13.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1062 γάμος, G2845 κοίτη, G0283 ἀμίαντος, G4205 πόρνος, G3432 μοιχός

Force. Timios ho gamos en pasin kai he koite amiantos, pornous gar kai moichous krinei ho theos. Marriage (gamos) is honorable and the bed (koite) undefiled (amiantos), bounded by gamos itself, and God will judge pornous and moichous. Listing pornous separately from moichous lexically distinguishes sexual immorality (including non-adulterous fornication) from adultery, so porneia is not narrowed to adultery alone.

1Cor.6.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2853 κολλάομαι, G4204 πόρνη, G4983 σῶμα

Force. Ho kollomenos te porne hen soma estin. He cites Gen 2:24, esontai gar phesin hoi duo eis sarka mian, to argue that joining to a porne (sexual partner outside marriage) creates the one-flesh bond, but in the wrong place. The argument only works if one-flesh union is by lexical definition the husband-wife bond, so sexual joining outside marriage misuses the union.

1Cor.6.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G4203 πορνεύω, G4983 σῶμα, G0265 ἀμάρτημα

Force. Pheugete ten porneian. Pan hamartema ho ean poiese anthropos ektos tou somatos estin, ho de porneuon eis to idion soma hamartanei. The imperative is unrestricted (flee porneia), and the participle ho porneuon (the one committing porneia) is described as sinning against his own body, with no carve-out for an unmarried participant.

1Cor.7.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G2398 ἴδιος, G2192 ἔχω

Force. Dia de tas porneias hekastos ten heautou gynaika echeto kai hekaste ton idion andra echeto. The remedy for porneia is for each man to have his own wife and each woman her own husband, naming gyne and aner as the licit channel for sexual relations. The reasoning presupposes that sexual relations outside that pair count as porneia.

1Thess.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0038 ἁγιασμός, G4202 πορνεία

Force. Touto gar estin thelema tou theou, ho hagiasmos hymon, apechesthai hymas apo tes porneias. God's will is identified with hagiasmos, identified in turn with abstaining from porneia. The genitive tes porneias is the unqualified category of illicit sexual intercourse.

1Thess.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4632 σκεῦος, G5092 τιμή, G0038 ἁγιασμός

Force. Eidenai hekaston hymon to heautou skeuos ktasthai en hagioismo kai time. Each is to know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor, paired with the contrast in v. 5 me en pathei epithymias kathaper kai ta ethne, that is, not in the passion of lust like the nations. The vocabulary heautou skeuos plus hagioismos plus time matches the marriage-bed honor formula of Heb 13:4.

1Thess.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G1484 ἔθνος

Force. Me en pathei epithymias kathaper kai ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon. The believer's conduct is set against pathos epithymias, the passion of lust, characteristic of the nations who do not know God. The lexical opposition places unregulated sexual desire outside the sanctified pattern.

Eph.5.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G0167 ἀκαθαρσία

Force. Porneia de kai akatharsia pasa e pleonexia mede onomazestho en hymin. Porneia and all impurity must not even be named among the saints, an emphatic prohibition that treats porneia as wholly outside the believing community's life.

Eph.5.31 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4347 προσκολλάω, G4561 σάρξ

Force. Anti toutou kataleipsei anthropos ton patera kai ten metera kai proskollethesetai pros ten gynaika autou, kai esontai hoi duo eis sarka mian. Paul restates Gen 2:24 in connection with husband and wife, fixing the one-flesh bond as the marital bond and providing the NT lexical anchor for the husband-wife scope of sexual union.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Heb.13.4	Gen.2.24	tsk	1
1Cor.6.16	Gen.2.24	openbible	1
Eph.5.31	Gen.2.24	openbible	1
1Cor.6.18	Gen.39.12	tsk	1
1Thess.4.3	1Cor.6.18	openbible	1
Eph.5.3	Eph.5.5	tsk	1
Deut.22.21	1Cor.5.1	openbible	1
1Cor.7.2	1Cor.7.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Exod.22.16 · addressed

Exod 22:16-17 sets the case of a man seducing an unbetrothed virgin: the resolution is that he must pay the mohar (bride-price) and marry her, or pay the bride-price if her father refuses. The case treats the act as a wrong requiring restitution and channels the relation into marriage. It does not treat unmarried sex as morally indifferent. It treats it as a sexual offense whose remedy is to constitute the marriage the act anticipated.

Deut.22.28 · addressed

Deut 22:28-29 sets the same kind of case (unbetrothed virgin) with mandatory marriage and a fine, again channeling the act into marriage rather than treating it as licit. The vocabulary of taphas and shakab marks the intercourse, and the requirement to marry signals that the relation was meant to be marital.

Gen.16.4 · addressed

Patriarchal narratives (Abraham with Hagar, Jacob with Bilhah and Zilpah) record concubinage and surrogate-bearing arrangements. The narrative records these arrangements without lexically endorsing them, and the prophetic and torah vocabulary (zanah, betulim, naaph) continues to bracket sexual relations inside the man-wife pair. Genre is descriptive narrative not legal warrant.

1Cor.7.36 · addressed

The interpretive crux at 1 Cor 7:36-38 concerns either a father-of-a-virgin reading or a betrothed-couple reading. On either reading the resolution is to marry (gameitosan), which keeps the licit channel for sexual relations inside gamos. The lexical pattern of the doctrine is unaffected.

Concordance traversed

G4202, G4203, G4204, G4205, G1062, G1060, G2845, G0283, G2853, G3432, G3431, G0038, G0167, G1939, G0265, G4983, G1392, H1692, H1320, H0259, H1331, H2181, H5003

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle. The marginal gar in Heb 13:4 and the bracketed pasa in Eph 5:3 are minor and do not touch the load-bearing terms porneia, koite, amiantos, hamartanei, gamos, or pornos. The 1 Cor 7:36-38 textual issues affect the referent of the parthenos but not the imperative to marry. These NT epistles fall outside the published CBGM scope, hence ecm-shadow.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. lexical_semantic_range_of_porneia, creation_one_flesh_paradigm

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

broad_porneia_plus_one_flesh_paradigm: affirms · Reading porneia as the standing broad category of illicit sexual intercourse (its range includes the incest of 1 Cor 5:1, prostitution of 1 Cor 6:16, and the general category in 1 Thess 4:3 and Eph 5:3), combined with the Gen 2:24 one-flesh formula cited at Matt 19:5, 1 Cor 6:16, and Eph 5:31, yields a verdict that sexual relations are reserved for the husband-wife pair and that pre-marital and non-marital sexual union falls under porneia.

narrow_porneia_as_specific_offense: affirms · Even if porneia were read narrowly in some contexts (cult prostitution, incest, or sex with prostitutes specifically), the positive boundary remains: gamos is honorable and koite amiantos (Heb 13:4), the one-flesh formula in Gen 2:24 is restricted to a man and his wife, and 1 Cor 7:2 names a man's own wife and a woman's own husband as the remedy for porneia. The marriage-bed boundary stands even on a narrow reading of porneia.

betrothal_or_marriage_stage_qualification: affirms · Some readers note that the OT case law in Exod 22:16-17 and Deut 22:28-29 envisions the sexual act constituting or anticipating marriage rather than being free of consequence. Stated in its strongest form, this lens still classifies the unmarried sexual act as a sexual offense requiring formal marriage and bride-price, never as morally neutral. The proposition that sex is reserved for marriage is preserved.

redemptive_historical_progressive_strictening: affirms · On a redemptive-historical reading, the OT permits some practices (polygamy, concubinage in patriarchal narrative) that the NT does not endorse, and the NT consolidates sexual ethics around the Gen 2:24 monogamous pair (Matt 19:5, 1 Cor 7:2, Eph 5:31). The trajectory tightens,

never loosens, the boundary around sex inside the husband-wife pair, so the verdict holds across the canonical arc.

The verdict rests on two pillars that converge: the standing semantic range of porneia plus its OT cognate zanah, and the Gen 2:24 one-flesh formula cited three times in the NT. *analogia_scripturae* is engaged because 1 Cor 7:2 supplies the licit channel (gyne, aner) that the prohibition presupposes. *progressive_revelation* is engaged because the NT tightens the one-flesh formula to a single husband-wife pair while OT narrative tolerated practices the NT does not endorse.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem labels pre-marital sex and sexual cohabitation as sin. This is the lexical conclusion of the cited terms rather than a tradition-specific taxonomy: the word sin tracks hamartanei and hamartema in 1 Cor 6:18, abstention tracks apechesthai apo tes porneias in 1 Thess 4:3, the OT case law uses zanah (H2181) in Deut 22:21, and the marriage boundary tracks gamos plus koite amiantos in Heb 13:4 plus the Gen 2:24 one-flesh formula. The parenthetical gloss fornication for porneia is a standard lexical equivalence, not a loaded framing, so no neutralization is required.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4202
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2845
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0283
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2181
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1692
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1331
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.13.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.2.24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.22.20
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.3
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.22.21
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.13.4
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.6.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.5.31

License audit

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